

Guiding Questions for GCT Strategy

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Add in your thoughts to the questions below! We should all have edit access.

What defines the Global Conflict Tracker?

- An accessible explanation of the history and drivers of a conflict with updates on the latest news that keep the pages dynamic

Who is GCT for? Who is GCT not for?

- Primarily for high school and college students, or anyone with limited knowledge looking to learn more about a conflict
- Occasionally useful for analysts/journalists/hill staff/other policy professionals looking to track recent developments of a conflict
- GCT is not for experts

What makes it similar to other trackers? What makes it different from other trackers? (At CFR or beyond)

- Other conflict trackers
 - GCT is more of a “one-stop-shop” where all conflicts can be accessed through the map page, whereas other organizations that focus solely on war/conflict are tying the map to more routine policy reports; the conflict maps for most of these trackers are static graphics that are updated month to month
 - Many of these other trackers are very technical; the websites often make it difficult to find what you’re looking for
 - [Armed Conflict Location & Event Data](#)
 - Explore by theme: election watch, actor profiles, conflict watch, political violence/targeting local officials
 - ACLED’s definition of political violence doesn’t match many other organizations and doesn’t have a specific terrorism label
 - [International Crisis Group’s Crisis Watcher](#):
 - Early warning: resolution opportunity, risk alert
 - Trends: improved situation, deteriorated situation, unchanged situation, standby monitoring, not monitored
 - Beyond this, not much information
 - When you hover over a conflict, it will give you a helpful, color-coded timeline
 - Türkiye: deteriorating situation (Oct 24), unchanged situation (Nov 24, Dec 24, Jan 25), resolution opportunity (Mar 25)

- And the equivalent of a long latest news update justifying the classification
- [International Institute for Strategic Studies Myanmar Conflict Map](#):
 - Like how they prominently link to recent publications
 - Like their filters:
 - Event type: attack/armed clash, remote explosive/IEDs air/drone, strike, crackdowns, infrastructure destruction
 - Events per month
 - Warscape: dry zone, Rakhine, Northeast, Southeast, Northwest, Lower Myanmar
 - Actor groups involved: SAC forces, anti-SAC forces, ethnic armed organizations, unattributed
- Other trackers
 - [Lowy Institute Southeast Asia Aid Map](#)
 - I really like how the information is displayed and you can filter for different information, like partner, recipient, year, sector, spent vs. committed

What does GCT already do well?

- Provides an explainer/backgrounder to a wide variety of conflicts
- Labels make it easy to find from simple google searches - drives a large portion of traffic
- Enduring relevance - pages are dynamic and consistently updated as news breaks

What could the GCT do better?

- Specifying methodological choices
 - Conflict status: how do we determine whether a conflict is improving, unchanging, or worsening, and what time frame are we comparing it against?
 - Could cite an event/development that justifies a change in status
 - Conflict type: political instability is usually an exacerbating factor in addition to an additional type of conflict, for instance, criminal violence in Haiti is fueled by a lack of governance/failed state status
 - Could allow for conflicts to be given multiple conflict types
 - Conflict's significance to U.S. interests: given the changing nature of what the Trump administration designates as in the U.S. interest, how useful is this determination?
 - Would suggest removing/reworking
- Providing useful data
 - Detailed maps to show where conflict is happening within a country
 - Integrating existing CFR timelines could help us show change over time

GCT Research Plan

- Use of satellite imagery for “Growth of an Informal Refugee Camp in Chad” graphic in the [“Crisis in Sudan: War, Famine, and a Failing Global Response”](#) article is a great example
- Spotighting other CFR content
 - Using clips from Meetings and videos made for social media
- Visually demonstrating how conflicts are interconnected/not restricted to discrete nation-states
 - This has been a challenge since October 7. Almost all of the conflicts in the Middle East are connected to Israel-Palestine (Conflict With Hezbollah in Lebanon, Confrontation With Iran, Instability in Iraq), but they also have their own unique dynamics. I’m sure there are people who navigate to the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict page looking for content related to Israel’s war against Hezbollah, etc. We link to other relevant pages in the intro section, not sure if there’s a better way to do that visually
- Improve navigation so you can find specific information easily (for example, a user comes to the site for more information on a conflict under a specific leader, not for the full overview)

Research Questions

Research Questions

What do we want to find out? What hypotheses do we want to test?

1. How do our users define “conflict”?
 - a. What is classified as a conflict?
 - i. Venezuela Crisis
 - ii. Instability in the Northern Triangle (criminal violence)
 - iii. Iran (proxies)
 - iv. Taiwan (potential - interstate or territorial dispute??)
2. Are conflict categories, status, and impact to U.S. interests useful metrics for users?
 - a. Would it be helpful to provide a description for the different conflict types?
3. What types of information are users looking for?
 - a. User expectations
 - b. Breaking news alert
 - c. Latest News Archive: search or filters by time period
 - i. Are users interested in this function?
 - d. How can users tell a full story? Fill in gaps
 - e. 3 months back
 - f. Killed, injured, displaced
4. Importance of the map vs conflict pages
 - a. How many users land on the map vs landing on a conflict page?
 - i. If you land on a conflict page, do you go to the map? Other conflicts?
 1. Nearby conflicts - are users using it and would a different relationships be better?
 - b. How important is the map showing overall conflict in the world?
 - c. Is the map a starting point? Do users go look at other conflicts?
5. What key information is important for users at first glance?
 - a. What is important for users when they first land on the map?
 - b. What grabs their interest in the tooltip?
 - c. Are numbers important here?
 - d. **How important is it for a conflict to have an impact on the U.S.?**
6. Are the “conflict types” clear to users?
 - a. How would a user define conflict?
 - b. Would it be helpful to provide a description for the different conflict types?
7. What are the differences in experience between students that have a specific goal in mind and those who don’t?

8. Do our current users (or users we want to reach) care about seeing conflict trends?
 - a. More conflict-level trends?
 - b. More macro-level trends?
9. Are users seeing latest news?
10. What is “interactive” about GCT?
11. Are types useful? Understood?

PPS-informed “areas to watch”?

- Bangladesh
- Egypt

Borders under stress